

p 1 – Product Description

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Table of Contents

 Introduction	3
1 Problem	3
2 Solution	3
2.1 Key Product Features and Capabilities	4
2.2 Major Components.....	4
3 Identification of Case Study	4
4 Glossary	6
5 References	7

t of Figures

List of Tables

Introduction

Food recalls are always relevant, and keeping up with this information is anything but easy. Current tools for tracking food recalls are fragmented and difficult to use. This information must be easily accessible to the public; without it, not only do consumers stand to be at risk of illnesses and allergies, but companies themselves can be liable to lawsuits and controversy.

1 Problem

Everyone is affected by recalls or the lack thereof. Parents who are trying to feed  their kids, individuals with allergies who must be cautious with what they are putting into their bodies, or immunocompromised individuals cannot afford to make any kind of mistake. Or the other end of the spectrum, where producers like farmers need to know about chemicals or produce, they use being recalled, or stores and restaurants that want to avoid the trouble that comes with dealing with recalled products. Each of these problems compound each other;  there's the awareness gap, where FDA/USDA announcements make their way to the average person slowly, leaving consumers unaware. Then there are the customization, engagement, and urgency gaps, where most consumers n't even think about how important these recalls can be, since there are no reliable, consistent channels for feeding relevant information to the public, as well as no way to tailor to these individuals.

2 Solution

Spoiler Alert aims to solve these problems by being a one-size-fits-all tool with push notifications, receipt/barcode scanning, and the ability to tailor to a user's needs and concerns, like allergies specific to them, with reliable data directly from the FDA and USDA.

2.1 Key Product Features and Capabilities

Spoiler Alert will streamline recall awareness and tailor will allow the user to create a specialized experience for themselves. The app will provide real-time notifications with alerts as recalls happen to keep the user updated at all times. A server hosted database will be utilized to synchronize these updates to users. Similarly, users will be able to filter through these recalls in the database by category such as food, cosmetics, and medicine.

Major Components

Spoiler Alert servers will be relied on to pull data using the FDA's API to alert users. This same server will also be used to allow users to save previous purchases to help with related recalls in the future.

3 Identification of Case Study

The single mother goes to the grocery store and buys some chicken to make for her and her children for dinner. She scans her receipt into the app after her purchase to log all her groceries into her personalized inventory. The next day, she plans to use the chicken, but the app sends an alert from the app that it has been recalled due to salmonella. Luckily, she received this alert before her or her children consumed it.

Features

She will be able to use the personalized inventory in the web-app to log the purchases they want to watch for recalls in the case something in her fridge is not safe for her family. This can be entered in manually using the barcode or receipt with email notifications being pushed upon new recalls appearing for these items.

3.2 Future Capabilities

When users upgrade to a premium account, they will no longer encounter sponsored advertisements on the web-app for a better user experience.

3.3 Other Potential Users

The user base in mind that may be part of the target audience are users with particular dietary restrictions or children, business owners and managers, and immune compromised individuals that must be extra careful with their food selection. 

4 Glossary

- Product Recall: When a manufacturer notifies the market of a product with a defect or potential danger.
- FDA: Food and Drug Administration
- CDC: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention
- UPC: Universal Product Code
- USDA: U.S. Department of Agriculture
- CPSC: U.S. Consumer Product Safety Commission
- openFDA API: The way SpoilerAlert is accessing FDA Data.
- Barcode Lookup API: The way SpoilerAlert is accessing FDA Data.

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